

# What Can Mongolian Tell Us about Binding?

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Jun 28, 2026

## Abstract

Drawing on Mongolian data, this paper proposes that syntactic binding arises as Agree between the phi-features on a predicate-internal subject and those in the specifier of an anaphor as a possessive DP in a lower position on the one hand, and is reassessed when the subject moves up to a position intertwining with verbal inflections on the other hand, leading to the distinction between predicate-internal (phase-based) and predicate-external (inflection-based) binding. Predicate-external binding occurs when this Agree is followed by Move (of the subject from inside the predicate into the inflectional domain), while predicate-internal binding occurs without Move. The paper aligns with the pre-Minimalist Standard Binding Theory by defining TP as the binding domain for external binding, and with the current Minimalist binding theories by using the vP/VoiceP phase boundary for internal binding. It argues that the locality of syntactic binding holds for predicate-external binding, arising from verbal inflections, and that the Anaphor Agreement Effect holds for predicate-internal binding, stemming from the “immaturity” of the internal subject as the binder before inflectional properties are assigned to the predicate, rather than from a capsule-like structure of anaphors.

**Keywords** predicate-internal/external binding, reflexive, possessive, anaphor, Agree

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## 1 Introduction

This paper explicates the nature of reflexive binding in Mongolian and demonstrates its theoretical implications for our understanding of binding in general.

In syntax, the shift from the pre-minimalist (i.e., Government & Binding/GB) to the minimalist (i.e., Minimalist Program/MP) era saw binding theory move from rule-bound modules (like Binding Conditions A, B, C) to a combination of principles of economy and feature-checking under minimalist operations (e.g., Agree and Move/Merge). Pre-minimalism regarded binding domains to be defined by a Governing Category involving the anaphor, its governor, and a subject, whereas in (later) minimalist syntax, a phase, which is a cyclic unit in syntactic derivation, provides a way to define binding domains (Lee-Schoenfeld 2004, 2008; Canac-Marquis 2005; Hicks 2009; Gallego 2010; Safir 2011; Antonenko 2012; Bošković 2016). Thus, the binding domain for the anaphor in sentences such as (1) underwent a shift from TP, the inflectional phrase, to vP, the thematic phrase.

(1) Pasha loves herself: [<sub>TP</sub> Pasha<sub>i</sub> ... herself<sub>i</sub>] → [<sub>vP=phase</sub> Pasha<sub>i</sub> ... herself<sub>i</sub>]

The minimalist approach to binding is largely considered superior to pre-minimalist theories because it takes binding to be streamlined within the derivation of the clause structure. However, significant debate remains concerning *what mechanism binding is exactly and how it is implemented*. At least three specific approaches from the minimalist literature on binding can be mentioned: the feature-valuation approach (Reuland 2011), the feature-transmission approach (Kratzer 2009), and the feature-matching approach (Preminger 2019). The feature-valuation approach, also called the reductionist approach, views binding as reducible to Agree, at least for SE-anaphors, where they originate as elements underspecified for phi-features, which are unvalued but matched and valued by phi-features of the binder via an Agree relation. The feature-transmission approach holds that the binder transmits its phi-features to the bound anaphor, which enters the derivation as a featureless minimal pronoun. The feature-matching approach, also called the encapsulation approach, arguing against the reductionist approach, holds that full agreement in phi-features between the anaphor and its antecedent is prevented by a structural layer (AnaphP) on top of the phi-feature layer, which is thus encapsulated, and that binding is feature-matching, not feature-valuation, within opaque domains.

Another controversial issue is about *which of vP (the phasal, thematic domain) and TP (the inflectional domain) is the right site in which to implement binding*. Kratzer (2009), Rooryck and Vanden Wyngaerd (2011), and others argue that phi-features of anaphors start out from the specifier of vP, which is thus the binding domain. For Reuland (2011), however, binding is intertwined with Case of a local subject and implemented through Agree within vP and Move within TP. That is, anaphors find their antecedents within vP, which, being a phase, serves as the structural boundary for Agree, but binding as Agree is completed within TP, where a linked chain is formed between anaphors, being phi-deficient, and their antecedents, being structural-Case-marked and phi-complete (Reuland and Everaert 2000; Reuland 2001, 2005, 2011, 2020). In this sense, TP could still be regarded as a domain for binding, echoing the pre-minimalist treatment of binding domain, although Reuland's research attempts to determine boundaries for binding by Agree and chain formation and avoids explicitly identifying an inflected phrase such as TP as a binding domain.

There also exist controversies about *the nature of reflexivity and anaphors*. For Kratzer (2009), anaphors enter the derivation as “minimal pronouns” lacking inherent phi-features and

get phi-values by being bound by  $\lambda$ -operators on functional heads, which acts as a conduit for feature-transmission, while for Reuland (2011), they are born with unvalued phi-features, which may be deficient, and get phi-values by being involved in chains formed between anaphors and their antecedents. For Preminger (2019), anaphors are capsule-like structures, where the phi-layer is encapsulated by the anaphor-layer on top of it and therefore fails to fully agree with a nominal in a higher position.

As will be clear, the first and the third controversies arise where anaphors, particularly those consisting of a body(-part) noun and its possessor, are not correctly analyzed as possessive DPs formed in a portmanteau fashion, and the second arises where phase-based binding (predicate-internal) is undistinguished from inflection-based binding (predicate-external).

Importantly, while, in the pre-minimalist era, verbal inflection was often taken as the hallmark of a boundary for syntactic binding, with inflected clauses generally allowing less freedom for anaphors than uninflected clauses, the role of inflection has been unclear in resolving the above-mentioned controversial issues in the minimalist era. In Reuland’s approach, verbal inflection plays a role in forming a feature-chain, but it is not a factor that can affect binding in other approaches. The connection between verbal inflection and binding has been removed or at least loosened by the combination of binding with the notion of phase in minimalist syntax.

This paper shows that verbal inflection and phasehood are equally crucial in implementing binding as a derivational process, not a representational constraint. Binding spans vP and TP, being closely correlated to subject positions as well as verbal inflection. Binding as phi-agreement takes place with phasehood, where the subject as the binder is within the uninflected predicate (vP), and therefore it is “predicate-internal binding”, whereas it is reassessed with verbal inflection, where the subject has moved into the inflectional domain (TP), and therefore it is “predicate-external binding”. Accordingly, verbal inflection is a key factor in deriving predicate-external binding from the predicate-internal binding. Mongolian data will tell us that the distinction between the two types of binding can be morphologically realized where possible.

This paper is organized as follows. **Sections 2 and 3** overview the basic properties of the anaphor *öör* and the reflexive-possessive suffix *-AA* in Mongolian, focusing on the conditions and/or constraints on their positions and interactions. **Section 2** illustrates that the anaphor *öör* functions an object, a possessor, and an embedded subject and that it can be absent at PF when RX is present elsewhere as a reflexive marker. **Section 3** explains that RX is required by conjoint reference but obstructed by disjoint reference and that it is licensed by the subject of a local inflected clause. **Section 4** justifies that reflexivity arises between specifiers and presents a “portmanteau” approach to the formation of possessive pronouns and anaphors, arguing that they are formed through clustering of relevant features including [phi], [possessive], and [reflexive] on independent D heads. D heads undergo fusion to become a single head, followed by vocabulary insertion, thereby forming an anaphor. **Section 5** presents argumentation that for a binder which is an in-situ subject within the predicate, binding is just Agree in phi-features between it and a c-commanded anaphor, hence the label “predicate-internal binding”, while for a binder which is a derived subject outside the predicate, binding is Agree plus Move, hence the label “predicate-external binding”. It will be shown that reflexive binding always holds between two Specs, of which the higher one is Spec of vP, occupied by a subject, and the lower one is either Spec of DP, occupied by a possessor or a genitive embedded subject, or Spec of

CP, occupied by an accusative embedded subject. **Section 6** clarifies the categorial status of RX as a clitic, which occupies the rightmost position of a phrase requiring it. It will be shown that RX is inserted after all other syntactic nodes of the phrase are realized. **Section 7** concludes the paper.

## 2 Basics of the anaphor *öör*

*Öör* serves primarily three grammatical roles: object, possessor and subject.<sup>1</sup> We discuss each situation in Sections 2.1, 2.2, and 2.3, and summarize them in Section 2.4.

### 2.1. *Öör* as an object

When used as an object, *öör* may refer to a local subject, where the reflexive-possessive suffix *-AA*, notated as RX,<sup>2</sup> is present, as in (2) and (3), or a long-distance subject, where the (non-reflexive) third-person possessive suffix *-ni*, notated as POSS[3],<sup>3</sup> is present, as in (4).

- (2) Dorž<sup>4</sup>      *öör-ig-öö*      *šüümžil-sen*.  
 Dorž-NOM   self-ACC-RX   criticize-PST  
 ‘Dorž criticized himself.’

- (3) Baatar<sub>i</sub>      Dorž<sub>j</sub>-in      *öör\*<sub>i/j</sub>-ig-öö*      *šüümžil-sen-ig*      har-san.  
 Baatar-NOM   Dorž-GEN   self-ACC-RX   criticize-PST-ACC   see-PST  
 ‘Baatar saw that Dorž criticized himself (= Dorž).’

- (4) Baatar<sub>i</sub>      Dorž<sub>j</sub>-in      *öör<sub>i</sub>/\*<sub>j</sub>-ig-ni*      *šüümžil-sen-ig*      har-san.  
 Baatar-NOM   Dorž-GEN   self-ACC-POSS[3]   criticize-PST-ACC   see-PST  
 ‘Baatar saw that Dorž criticized him (= Baatar).’

### 2.2. *Öör* as a possessor

When used as a possessor, *öör*, taking genitive case, may be absent on the surface. Importantly, RX must be present on the possessed noun in the case of *öör*’s absence, as in (5). However, when present, the genitive *öör-in* can host RX, as in (6).

- (5) Baatar      (*öör-in*)      nom-*φ-oo*<sup>5</sup>      mart-san.

<sup>1</sup> *Öör*, being a singular form, is specified for number but not for person and gender. The plural form is *öör-sd* (or *öör-üüd*, which is used interchangeably in colloquial Mongolian in eastern Inner Mongolia), which takes a plural antecedent but is not specified for person and gender. The grammatical functions of the singular and plural forms are entirely the same; both can function as objects, possessors, and subjects.

<sup>2</sup> RX, being subject to vowel harmony, has four allophonic morphemes, *-aa*, *-ee*, *-oo* and *-öö*, which do not differ from each other syntactically and semantically.

<sup>3</sup> Unlike RX, POSS[3] is attached to an element with a third person possessor. Mongolian also has POSS[1] and POSS[2]. For relevant descriptions, see Cinggeltei (1999: 179–180), Janhunen (2012: 137–138), and Kullmann and Tserenpil (2015: 106–107) among many.

<sup>4</sup> As nominative case marking is null in Mongolian, the nominative subject in the examples is left without being assigned a null morpheme in the first line while being glossed as NOM in the second line.

<sup>5</sup> When followed by RX, the accusative marker *-ig* is mostly unpronounced except when it is attached to the anaphor *öör*. Guntsetseg (2012: 106) reports that *-ig* occurs almost exclusively with kinship and friendship terms. However, the cooccurrence of *-ig* and RX for kinship terms is not obligatory. For example, sentences containing *aab-aa* are readily found in Google, although speakers, especially those of Khalkha Mongolian, refrain from using it in order to avoid an ambiguity between it and the vocative *aab-aa*. Khalkha speakers thus tend to use *aab-ig-aa*, while speakers of varieties in which the end sound *n* has been retained (i.e., *-aan*) are more likely to use the more compact form *aab-aan*, not the longer *aab-ig-aan*. This means that where there is no potential ambiguity between the reflexive *-aa* and the vocative *-aa*, *-ig* is less likely to be overt.

- Baatar-NOM self-GEN book-ACC-**RX** forget-PST  
‘Baatar forgot his own book.’
- (6) Baatar öör-in-**öö**<sup>6</sup> nom-ig mart-san.  
Baatar-NOM self-GEN-**RX** book-ACC forget-PST  
‘Baatar forgot his own book.’

### 2.3. *Öör* as the subject of subordinate clauses

Both object clauses, with or without the complementizer *gež*, and object relative clauses can have *öör* as their subject, where RX is present. Situations differ according to the types of clauses. When used as the subject of object clauses headed by *gež*, *öör* takes accusative case and cannot be absent (7). Without *öör*, the covert embedded subject is interpreted as a nonspecific person.

- (7) Baatar öör-ig-**öö** buruud-san gež med-sen. (object clause)  
Baatar-NOM self-ACC-**RX** go wrong-PST COMP know-PST  
‘Baatar realized that he was wrong.’

When used as the subject of object clauses without being headed by *gež* and relative clauses, *öör* takes genitive case and can be absent.<sup>7</sup> RX is present either on *öör*, as in (8) and (10), when it is present, or on the verb, as in (9) and (11).

- (8) Baatar öör-in-**öö** buruud-san-ig meder-sen. (object clause)  
Baatar-NOM self-GEN-**RX** go wrong-PST-ACC admit-PST  
‘Baatar admitted that he was wrong.’
- (9) Baatar (öör-in) buruud-san- $\phi$ -**aa** meder-sen. (object clause)  
Baatar-NOM self-GEN go wrong-PST-ACC-**RX** admit-PST  
‘Baatar admitted that he was wrong.’
- (10) Baatar öör-in-**öö** hel-sen üg-ig mart-san. (relative clause)  
Baatar-NOM self-GEN-**RX** say-PST word-ACC forget-PST  
‘Baatar forgot the words he said.’
- (11) Baatar (öör-in) hel-sen üg- $\phi$ -**ee** mart-san. (relative clause)  
Baatar-NOM self-GEN say-PST word-ACC-**RX** forget-PST  
‘Baatar forgot the words he said.’

This is evidenced by the fact that even in Khalkha Mongolian, the kinship term for a junior relative such as *ohin* ‘daughter’, which is less likely to be vocative, disfavors or even disallows *-ig*; that is, *ohin-ig-oo* is not or less acceptable. In this paper, I consistently use “- $\phi$ ” to indicate the absence of this accusative marker *-ig*.

<sup>6</sup> For phonological reasons, the consonant *h* is often inserted between the *n* and a vowel, as in *öör-in-h-öö* (Cinggeltei 1999: 181; Janhunen 2012: 141), while being consistently left out in the examples in this paper. This *h* must not be confused with the minimal noun *h* as in *Ene nom mini-h* ‘This book is mine’. The former is epenthetic whereas the latter is not. The latter, which behaves the same way as English *s* (e.g., *hers* and *John’s*), is the exponence of the nominal complement of a possessive D head, as is the case with the body anaphor *bey*. See Section 5 and related works including Kullmann and Tserenpil (2015: 101–102), Borjigin and Bai (2025), and Bai et al. (2026) for detailed discussion. See Section 6.1 for detailed discussion.

<sup>7</sup> The presence or absence of *öör* does not affect the referentiality-related interpretation of the sentence. It’s presence may bring an intensifying effect on the possessor. My survey utilizing Inner Mongolia University’s corpus *Juun tümen üg-tei odo üye-in Mongol helen-nii temdeg hadasan materal-in hömrög* (Tagged corpus of modern Mongolian, with one million words) shows that in definitely most cases, the anaphor is absent, with RX occurring independently. I searched for four frequently used nouns, *aab* ‘father’, *eež* ‘mother’, *ger* ‘house’, and *mori* ‘horse’, which are RX-marked, in the corpus and found 311 clauses in total but only five out of 311 feature the cooccurrence of *öör-in* and RX.

## 2.4. Interim summary

In summary, as shown in (41), *öör-in* (genitive) acts as a possessor in DPs and as the subject of object clauses without *gež* and relative clauses, which are categorially nominalized TP (Cf. Section 5.2). *Öör-ig* (accusative) acts as an object and as the subject of object clauses with *gež*, which are categorially CP (Cf. Section 5.2).

### (12) Distributional paradigm of *öör* (interaction of its case and grammatical functions)

|            | As an object | As a possessor | As a subject                                          |
|------------|--------------|----------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| Genitive   |              | possessive DP  | object clause without <i>gež</i> ;<br>relative clause |
| Accusative | DP object    |                | object clause with <i>gež</i>                         |

Regarding the position of RX, which is required for an overt *öör*, two positions are available. One follows the genitive and accusative case markers and the other follows the whole phrase.

### (13) Presence or absence of *öör-in* (genitive) and position of RX

| Genitive             |                         | Accusative         |
|----------------------|-------------------------|--------------------|
| <i>öör-in</i> -RX DP | ( <i>öör-in</i> ) DP-RX | <i>öör-ig</i> -RX  |
| absence disallowed   | absence allowed         | absence disallowed |

Importantly, the genitive *öör-in* can be absent at PF when RX occurs in the second type of position. Let us tentatively formulate this property as follows, without theoretical implications at the moment.

### (14) The Elsewhere Marker Condition (EMC)<sup>8</sup>

Genitive anaphors can be absent at PF where the associated RX is present elsewhere.

## 3 Basics of the reflexive-possessive suffix -A4

As seen in Section 2, *öör* always calls for the presence of RX, which plays the most crucial role in reflexive binding in Mongolian. Only elements other than nominative subjects can be attached by RX.<sup>9</sup> This paper, however, is concerned only with cases in which RX is attached to accusative-marked objects and genitive-marked subjects.

### 3.1. Co/Disjoint reference and -A4

This section focuses on the interactions of RX and the conjoint reference (CR) or disjoint reference (DR) between subjects or possessors. As can be summarized from Section 2, any of the following conditions must be satisfied where RX occurs.

#### (15) Conditions on RX

- The accusative anaphor (*öör-ig*) acts as an object that refers back to a local subject. (Cf. 16)
- The accusative anaphor (*öör-ig*) acts as the subject of an object clause with *gež*; and

<sup>8</sup> EMC is evidently correct in terms of the linear structure. It is, however, not simply a surface condition for a linear structure. The logic underlying it is essentially a matter of syntax and is hierarchically derived. See Section 6.2 for relevant discussion.

<sup>9</sup> Descriptive discussions are found in Poppe (1954: 78–84), Nasanbayar (1982: 232–233), Daobu (1983: 30–31), Cinggeltei (1999: 180–181), Anisman (2010: 17–18), Janhunen (2012: 140–141), and Kullmann and Tserenpil (2015: 108–112). Explanatory discussions on RX are found in studies including Guntsetseg (2012: 101–106), Maki et al. (2015: 67–80), Bai and Cao (2024: 51–52), Gong and Despić (2024, 2026), and Borjigin and Bai (2025).



refers back to the matrix subject. (Cf. 16)

- c. The genitive anaphor (*öör-in*) acts as the possessor in an object DP hosting RX; and refers back to a local subject. (Cf. 17)
- d. The genitive anaphor (*öör-in*) acts as the subject of a relative clause that modifies an NP hosting RX; and refers back to the matrix subject. (Cf. 18)
- e. The genitive anaphor (*öör-in*) acts as the subject of an object clause without *gež* that contains its predicate hosting RX; and refers back to the matrix subject. (Cf. 19)

Notably, the necessary condition of licensing RX is that coreference is obtained between a subject and *öör*, either accusative or genitive and either present or absent at PF. For (15c), (15d), and (15e), *öör* itself can host RX. Below (16–19) are the distributional paradigms of RX.

(16) Distributional paradigm of RX in objects (simplex anaphors) and object clauses with *gež*<sup>10</sup>

| NOM              | ACC                        | Example |
|------------------|----------------------------|---------|
| SBJ <sub>i</sub> | <i>öör<sub>i</sub></i> -RX | (2, 7)  |

(17) Distributional paradigm of RX in possessive DPs

| NOM              | GEN                        | ACC                 | Example |
|------------------|----------------------------|---------------------|---------|
| NP2 <sub>i</sub> | <i>öör<sub>i</sub></i> -RX | NP <sub>j</sub>     | (6)     |
| NP2 <sub>i</sub> | <i>öör<sub>i</sub></i>     | NP <sub>j</sub> -RX | (5)     |
| NP2 <sub>i</sub> |                            | NP <sub>j</sub> -RX | (5)     |

(18) Distributional paradigm of RX in DPs in relative clauses

| NOM              | GEN                        | ACC                    | Example |
|------------------|----------------------------|------------------------|---------|
| NP2 <sub>i</sub> | <i>öör<sub>i</sub></i> -RX | NP <sub>RELj</sub>     | (10)    |
| NP2 <sub>i</sub> | <i>öör<sub>i</sub></i>     | NP <sub>RELj</sub> -RX | (11)    |
| NP2 <sub>i</sub> |                            | NP <sub>RELj</sub> -RX | (11)    |

(19) Distributional paradigm of RX in object clauses without *gež*

| NOM              | GEN <sup>11</sup>          | ACC  | Example |
|------------------|----------------------------|------|---------|
| SBJ <sub>i</sub> | <i>öör<sub>i</sub></i> -RX | V    | (8)     |
| SBJ <sub>i</sub> | <i>öör<sub>i</sub></i>     | V-RX | (9)     |
| SBJ <sub>i</sub> |                            | V-RX | (9)     |

It then follows that CR feeds RX and DR obstructs it. Importantly, RX is licensed by the subject of a local inflected clause. This is exemplified below.

In (20), *muur* ‘cat’ is possessed by the embedded genitive subject *Bat*, which is within the same clause as *muur*. While being a bare noun, *muur* must be interpreted as being possessed by the subject. That is, there is an implicit possessive determiner heading the nominal phrase containing *muur*. That implicit possessive determiner is *öör-in* ‘self’s’, which refers to the subject *Bat*. This is evident from the fact that *öör-in* can be overt, yielding *öör-in muur* ‘self’s cat’ (Cf. (5)). Note that with RX, the cat cannot be interpreted as Baatar’s. RX is thus licensed by CR between the possessor, covert or overt, and the subject of the same clause.

(20) Baatar      Bat-in      muur- $\phi$ -aa      üns-sen-ig      har-san.  
Baatar-NOM   Bat-GEN   cat-ACC-RX   kiss-PST-ACC   see-PST  
‘Baatar saw that Bat kissed his cat (= Bat’s cat).’

<sup>10</sup> Case suffixes are all left out in these tables.

<sup>11</sup> The subject of object clauses without *gež* can also be ACC-marked, which is less often encountered in some dialects such as Khorchin.

In (21), RX on *muur* is licensed by RC between the covert possessor (of the cat) and the embedded subject *bagš* ‘teacher’. In contrast, RX on the embedded subject *bagš* is licensed by CR between the possessor (of the teacher) and the matrix subject.

(21) Baatar bagš-in-aa muur- $\phi$ -aa üns-sen-ig har-san.  
Baatar-NOM teacher-GEN-RX cat-ACC-RX kiss-PST-ACC see-PST

‘Baatar saw that his teacher (= Baatar’s teacher) kissed his cat (= teacher’s cat).’

The same holds true in sentences containing a relative clause. In (22), the teacher must be interpreted as Bat’s, not Baatar’s. That is, CR between Bat and the covert possessor (of the teacher) licenses RX.

(22) Baatar Bat-in bagš-aas-aa zeel-sen nom-ig-ni unš-sen.  
Baatar-NOM Bat-GEN teacher-ABL-RX borrow-PST book-ACC-POSS[3] read-PST

‘Baatar read the book that Bat borrowed from his teacher (= Bat’s teacher).’

In (23), the book is not interpreted as being physically possessed by the subject, while RX is present on *nom* ‘book’. This is because there is CR between the matrix subject and the subject of the relative clause. Semantically, with *nom* attached by RX, its referent, (the book) must be participated in two events with coreferential subjects.

(23) Baatar bagš-aas-aa zeel-sen nom- $\phi$ -oo unš-sen.  
Baatar-NOM teacher-ABL-RX borrow-PST book-ACC-RX read-PST  
‘Baatar read the book that he borrowed from his teacher (= Baatar’s teacher).’

Where there is DR, not CR, between the two subjects, RX cannot be attached on *nom* (24). The presence of RX leads to the ungrammaticality of the sentence.

(24) \*Baatar bagš-in-aa zeel-üül-sen nom- $\phi$ -oo unš-sen.  
Baatar-NOM teacher-GEN-RX borrow-PST book-ACC-RX read-PST  
‘Int. Baatar read the book that his teacher (= Baatar’s teacher) lent him.’

Instead of RX, POSS[3] is used where CR is not obtained (25). Note that the book participates in two events with disjoint subjects, Baatar and his teacher.

(25) Baatar bagš-in-aa zeel-üül-sen nom- $\phi$ -ni unš-sen.  
Baatar-NOM teacher-GEN-RX borrow-CS-PST book-ACC-POSS[3] read-PST  
‘Baatar read the book that his teacher (= Baatar’s teacher) lent him.’

The fact that DR is fed by CR but obstructed by DR also holds true of a double possessive DP in a simple clause. For example, *bagš-in-aa nom* ‘teacher’s book’ cannot take RX (26) but can take POSS[3] (27).

(26) \*Baatar bagš-in-aa nom- $\phi$ -oo unš-sen.  
Baatar-NOM teacher-GEN-RX book-ACC-RX read-PST  
‘Lit. Baatar read his teacher’s book (= Baatar’s teacher’s book).’

(27) Baatar bagš-in-aa nom- $\phi$ -ni unš-sen.  
Baatar-NOM teacher-GEN-RX book-ACC-POSS[3] read-PST  
‘Baatar read his teacher’s book (= Baatar’s teacher’s book).’

The contrast between (26) and (27) significantly resembles that between (24) and (25). All this indicates that RX is subject to locality constraint. Section 3.2 elaborates on this issue.

### 3.2. Licensing domain and locality of -AA

This subsection explicates that RX is licensed in an inflected local clause. As exemplified in (28), RX is licensed by CR between the anaphor *öör* and the embedded subject *Dorž*.



- (28) Baatar<sub>i</sub> Dorž<sub>j</sub>-in öör<sub>i/j</sub>-ig-öö šüümžil-sen-ig har-san.  
 Baatar-NOM Dorž-GEN self-ACC-RX criticize-PST-ACC see-PST  
 ‘Baatar saw that Dorž criticized himself (= Dorž).’

Where *öör* refers to the matrix subject, RX is not present on *öör*, but POSS[3] is (29).

- (29) Baatar<sub>i</sub> Dorž<sub>j</sub>-in öör<sub>i/\*j</sub>-ig-ni šüümžil-sen-ig med-ne.  
 Baatar-NOM Dorž-GEN self-ACC-POSS[3] criticize-PST-ACC know-NPST  
 ‘Baatar knows that Dorž criticized him (= Baatar).’

The same holds true of the case in which the embedded clause is headed by the complementizer *gež*, as exemplified in (30) and (31).

- (30) Baatar<sub>i</sub> Dorž<sub>j</sub>-ig öör<sub>i/j</sub>-ig-öö šüümžil-sen gež bod-son.  
 Baatar-NOM Dorž-ACC self-ACC-RX criticize-PST COMP think-PST  
 ‘Baatar thought that Dorž criticized himself (= Dorž).’

- (31) Baatar<sub>i</sub> Dorž<sub>j</sub>-ig öör<sub>i/\*j</sub>-ig-ni šüümžil-sen gež bod-son.  
 Baatar-NOM Dorž-ACC self-ACC-POSS[3] criticize-PST COMP think-PST  
 ‘Baatar thought that Dorž criticized him (= Baatar).’

Note that where RX is unavailable, the non-reflexive possessive marker POSS[3] (i.e., *-ni*) is needed. *-ni* is licensed by neither subject-subject CR nor subject-possessor CR. It is licensed by the coreference between an antecedent nominal, which may or may not be a subject but must not be a subject of an inflected local clause, and a possessor, which may or may not be overt,<sup>12</sup> as illustrated by (29), (31), and (32) as well as (22), (25), and (27) in Section 3.1.

- (32) Baatar<sub>i</sub> Dorž<sub>j</sub>-in hüü<sub>i</sub>-ig(-ni) šüümžil-sen.  
 Baatar-NOM Dorž-GEN son-ACC-POSS[3] criticize-PST  
 ‘Baatar criticized Dorž’s son.’

Importantly, RX is only present in a clause with verbal inflection, as evidenced by (33) (Cf. also (28) and (30), as well as (20–23) in Section 3.1.). Where the subject of an uninflected predicate binds the anaphor, POSS[3] rather than RX is present, as evidenced by (34), in which the agent *Dorž* is the subject of the uninflected transitive verb stem *unš* ‘read’.

- (33) Baatar<sub>i</sub> Dorž<sub>j</sub>-oor (öör<sub>i/\*j</sub>-in) nom- $\phi$ -oo unš-uul-san.  
 Baatar-NOM Dorž-INS self-GEN book-ACC-RX read-CS-PST  
 ‘Baatar made Dorž read his book (=Baatar’s book).’  
 (34) Baatar<sub>i</sub> Dorž<sub>j</sub>-oor (öör<sub>i/j</sub>-in) nom- $\phi$ -ni unš-uul-san.  
 Baatar-NOM Dorž-INS self-GEN book-ACC-POSS[3] read-CS-PST  
 ‘Baatar made Dorž read his book (=Dorž’s book).’

In short, the licensing domain for RX is a local inflected clause.<sup>13</sup>

<sup>12</sup> In (29) and (31), *öör* is an object on the surface, as discussed in Section 2.1. However, it is in fact the possessor within a possessive DP *öör-in-bey* ‘self’s body’, where the genitive marker *-in* and the minimal noun *bey* ‘body’ are absent at PF. See Section 4.2 for detailed discussion. Where the possessor *öör-in* is present in an ordinary possessive DP, POSS[3] is preferably attached to it, not to the accusative object.

(i) Bid tüün-ne öör-in-h-ni mori-ig unu-b. (Cinggeltei 1999: 220)  
 we-NOM he-GEN self-GEN-h-POSS[3] horse-ACC rise-PST  
 ‘We rode his horse; Lit. ‘We rode his self’s horse.’

<sup>13</sup> See Bai (2025) for the justification of the subjecthood of causees in Mongolian causatives. See also Footnote 22.

## 4. The nature of reflexivity and anaphors

### 4.1. Reflexivity as a Spec-Spec relation

In line with extensive discussion in the literature (Everaert 2012: 194; Cohen and Zribi-Hertz 2014; Volkova and Reuland 2014: 591; Reuland 2018: 91; Haspelmath 2023: 20), an informal characterization of reflexivity would be like (35) below.

(35) Reflexivity is a dependency between coarguments.

However, the definition in (35) can only account for reflexivity between a subject and an object (SO reflexivity), while failing to account for reflexivity between a subject and a possessor (SP reflexivity), and between a matrix subject and an embedded subject (SS reflexivity). The existence of SP and SS reflexivity in Mongolian, as discussed in Sections 2 and 3, significantly indicates that reflexivity should also be identified in a more general sense than (35).

To correctly identify reflexivity as a more general dependency, we need to explicate the principle underlying SS, SP and SO reflexivity, which are consistently expressed by the common marker RX. It is evident that SS and SP reflexivity is subsumed under Spec-Spec dependency. This paper argues that SO reflexivity is also a subtype of Spec-Spec dependency. To justify this, we need to first dissect the underlying possessive structure of reflexive/anaphoric objects, where there is a covert or over possessor in Spec of the possessive phrase.

Schladt (2000) reports that in a worldwide sample of 148 languages, approximately 60% (89 out of 148) used constructions that originated from body part terms, while the rate is 76% (47 out of 62) for König et al. (2005). Mongolian is no exception. The body anaphor *öör-in bey* ‘self’s body’ is evidently a possessive DP (36): *bey*, as the lexical core of the anaphor, is possessed by *öör*, which carries the referential meaning of the anaphor.

(36) Baatar<sub>i</sub>            öör<sub>i</sub>/\*j-in    bey- $\phi$ -ee            šüümžil-sen.  
Baatar-NOM    self-GEN    body-ACC-RX    criticize-PST  
‘Baatar criticized himself.’

In this sense, *-in* is a possessive determiner D, which selects *bey* as its complement and *öör* as its Spec, as represented below.

(37) [XP ... subject ... [DP possessor [D' D [N]]]

(38) [XP ... Baatar ... [DP *öör* [D' -in [*bey*]]]

This suggests that the bare anaphors *öör* in (39) and *bey* in (40) are in fact also realizations of the possessive structure (38). For *öör*, D and N have no content at PF, and for *bey*, D and its Spec have no content.

(39) Baatar<sub>i</sub>            öör<sub>i</sub>/\*j-ig-**öö**            šüümžil-sen.  
Baatar-NOM    self-ACC-RX    criticize-PST  
‘Baatar criticized himself.’

(40) Baatar<sub>i</sub>            bey<sub>i</sub>/\*j- $\phi$ -ee            šüümžil-sen.  
Baatar-NOM    body-ACC-RX    criticize-PST  
‘Baatar criticized himself.’

Cross-linguistically, possessive-structured body-anaphors are readily available, for example, *dèet gi* ‘their body’ in Anywa (Schladt 2000: 114), *kò a li* ‘his body’ in Haitian Creole (Rooryck and Vanden Wyngaerd 2011: 40), and *bere buruari* ‘their head’ in Basque (Haspelmath 2023: 26). These anaphors all behave in a very similar way to Mongolian *öör-in bey*. They all literally mean “self’s body/head”. Differences among such languages in the morpho-syntactic properties of anaphors are supposedly related to their lexicalization, which took place diachronically, as

well as language-specific ways of deriving pronouns and anaphors. Under a framework such as Distributed Morphology (Halle and Marantz 1993; Embick and Marantz 2008), all these elements can be analyzed as spelling out one or more terminal nodes resulting from an operation such as fusion (Bai et al. 2026).

Conceptually, a possessor-possessum relation is a kind of subject-object relation mediated by a functor. In this regard, the predicate is something like “*x holds y*”, where *holds* is a possessive predicate, *x* is an external argument, and *y* is an internal argument. In this sense, anaphoric objects as possessive DPs contain *x* (i.e., the possessor) in its Spec, which may be either overt or covert. Importantly, reflexivity arises between a subject and *x* (Cf. (36)), not between a subject and the entire possessive DP. In other words, reflexivity can be a Spec-Spec dependency (41); it may not necessarily be a Spec-Comp dependency.

(41) Reflexivity arises between specifiers.<sup>14</sup>

Specifically, the phi-features of a subject, which occupies a Spec position and those occupying the Spec of an anaphoric phrase (DP) come to match, thereby yielding reflexivity (Cf. Section 6). In this sense, the predicate in sentences such as (42) is reflexive. In (42), *Pasha* is in the Spec of TP/VoiceP and *her* in Spec of DP, which is the complement of the single predicate *love*.

(42) *Pasha<sub>i</sub> loves her<sub>i</sub> cat.*

According to Reinhart and Reuland (1993) and others (35), sentences like (42) are not reflexive since *her* and *Pasha* are not co-arguments despite the coreference between them. Importantly, however, the corresponding Mongolian sentence (43) is obviously reflexive, as morphologically evidenced: It is reflexive-marked by RX.

(43) *Pasha (öör-in) muur-φ-aa hairla-na.*  
*Pasha-NOM self-GEN cat-ACC-RX love-NPST*  
 ‘Pasha loves her (own) cat.’

Additionally, according to R&R’s claim that a reflexive predicate is reflexive-marked, the absence of an anaphoric element *self* as a reflexive marker in (42) renders the sentence non-reflexive. Importantly, however, the presence of an anaphoric element is not essential to reflexivity. The Mongolian genitive anaphor *öör-in* may be absent from the surface structure, indicating that anaphors are not obligatory reflexive markers.<sup>15</sup> This is connected to the fact that (42) is reflexive despite the lack of an anaphor such as *herself*. Thus, the absence of an anaphor in possessive DPs containing a bound pronoun cannot be used as evidence that reflexivity is not involved in sentences such as (42) and (43). Absence of evidence is not evidence of absence. On the other hand, cross-linguistically, anaphors, for example, Chinese *ziji* (44) and Japanese *zisin* (45) can easily be recovered in such DPs, without affecting the reflexive interpretation, as is the case with Mongolian.

(44) *Pasha<sub>i</sub> xihuan ta<sub>i</sub> (ziji)-de mao.*  
*Pasha love she (self)-GEN cat*  
 ‘Pasha loves her (own) cat.’

(45) *Pasha<sub>i</sub> kanozyo<sub>i</sub> (zisin)-no neko-o ai-suru.*

<sup>14</sup> Precisely speaking, reflexivity arises between the binder and the bindee located in specifiers, where the lower specifier must be the specifier of the leftmost phase within the domain targeted by the binder. A detailed formulation of this is provided in Bai (2026).

<sup>15</sup> Note that inalienable possession, often observed with kinship and body part nouns, is usually not expressed by any anaphoric items while obligatorily leading to subject-possessor coreference cross-linguistically.

Pasha she (self)-GEN cat-ACC love-NPST  
‘Pasha loves her (own) cat.’

All this said, it is undoubtedly true that reflexivity can arise between two specifier elements. This leads to the unified analysis of reflexive binding in nominals (DPs) and clausal structures (TPs), an issue to discuss in Section 6.

#### 4.2. Anaphors as possessive DPs

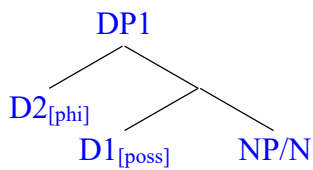
In this section, we elaborate on the internal structure of anaphors based on the discussion in Section 4.1. The core idea is that anaphors, at least those with possessive/genitive-marking such as body(-part) anaphors, are formed in a portmanteau fashion. Technically, (an element with)  $[\phi]$  sits in Spec,  $[\text{poss}]$  on D, and  $[\text{n}]$  on Comp, in the possessive DP structure, as shown below.

(56)  $[\text{DP } [\phi] [\text{D } [\text{poss}] [\text{N } [\text{n}]]]]$

To elaborate on this, we need to first look at how possessive pronouns are derived, taking English as an example. Previous studies on English (Abney 1987; Corver 1992; Chomsky 1995b; Munn 1995) suggest that possessors are merged in the specifier of DP, where the D head may be realized as *3*. Davis (2023) and Bai et al. (2026) argue that English possessive pronouns such as *her* are portmanteau morphemes spelling out multiple syntactic nodes with  $\phi$ -features ( $[\phi]$ ) and a possessive feature ( $[\text{poss}]$ ), which enter the derivation separately but undergo clustering. Bai et al. (2026) justify that anaphors such as *herself* are structurally the same as possessive DPs such as *her cat*, both being derived over (46a) through (46b).

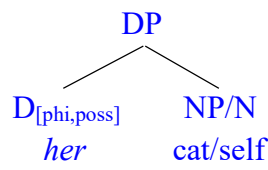
Specifically, possessive pronouns spell out the fused outcome of D and the material in its Spec. Based on a bare phrase structure theory of labeling (Chomsky 1995a, 1995b), in which non-projecting heads are equivalent to phrases, Davis (2023) and Bai et al. (2026) assume that a bare determiner  $\text{D2}_{[\phi]}$  occupies Spec of  $\text{D1}_{[\text{poss}]}$  (46a). After (46a) is built, D2 and D1 undergo fusion,<sup>16</sup> thereby creating a single terminal node, where the features on D1 and D2 are clustered. The vocabulary insertion (VI) rule then applies, with the morpheme *her* is chosen for D and *cat/self* for NP/N (46b).

(46) a. Initial structure



→→→

b. Ultimate structure



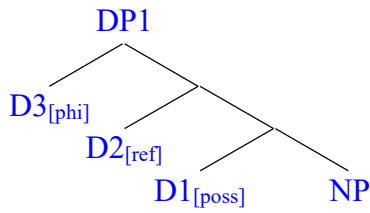
Below, let us look at how Mongolian anaphors are created out of respective formal features, based on Bai et al.'s (2026) analysis of English anaphors.

Given that reflexivity is syntactically conditioned by binding, it arises where  $[\phi]$  on a subject and that within the possessive DP agree. Specifically, the reflexivity feature  $[\text{ref}]$ , which is also located in Spec of  $\text{D}_{[\text{poss}]}$  (47a), is evoked by  $\phi$ -agreement, leading to the reflexive semantics (Cf. Section 5).  $\text{D1}_{[\text{poss}]}$  as the head of the structure undergoes fusion with  $\text{D3}_{[\phi]}$  and  $\text{D2}_{[\text{ref}]}$ , respectively (47b).<sup>17</sup>

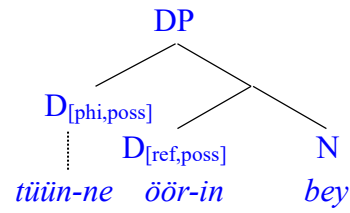
<sup>16</sup> *Fusion* here, a term of Distributed Morphology (Halle and Marantz 1993; Embick and Marantz 2008), refers to a syntactic operation that gets two (or more) nodes united into one before the application of the morphological operation VI.

<sup>17</sup> Note that four kinds of sets come out of these three features, namely,  $[\phi, \text{ref}]$ ,  $[\phi, \text{poss}]$ ,  $[\text{ref}, \text{poss}]$  and  $[\phi, \text{ref}, \text{poss}]$ , as inputs for clustering. However, clustering of features as well as fusion of heads is not

## (47) a. Initial structure



## b. Ultimate structure



→→→

$D_{[\text{phi}, \text{poss}]}$ ,  $D_{[\text{ref}, \text{poss}]}$ , and  $N$  are spelled out by the morphological units *tüün-ne* ‘her/his’, *öör-in* ‘self’s/own’, *bey*, respectively.<sup>18</sup> However, *öör-in bey-in čadal* ‘self’s body’s strength’ due to principles of economy such as (48), a spell-out with the smallest number of syllables, without affecting the reflexive possessive semantics, is favored.<sup>19</sup>

(48) Use as few morphemes as possible.<sup>20</sup>

This leads to the fact that either *öör* or *bey* is preferred to *öör-in bey*, while all being grammatical, as exemplified in (36), (39), and (40), repeated as (49), (50), and (51).

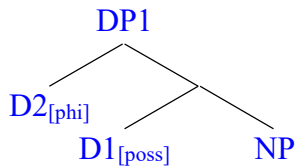
(49) Baatar<sub>i</sub>            öör<sub>i</sub>/\*j-in    bey- $\phi$ -ee            šüümžil-sen.  
 Baatar-NOM    self-GEN    body-ACC-RX    criticize-PST  
 ‘Baatar criticized himself.’

(50) Baatar<sub>i</sub>            öör<sub>i</sub>/\*j-ig-öö    šüümžil-sen.  
 Baatar-NOM    self-ACC-RX    criticize-PST  
 ‘Baatar criticized himself.’

(51) Baatar<sub>i</sub>            bey<sub>i</sub>/\*j- $\phi$ -ee    šüümžil-sen.  
 Baatar-NOM    body-ACC-RX    criticize-PST  
 ‘Baatar criticized himself.’

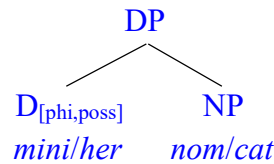
Non-reflexive possessive DPs such as *mini nom* ‘my book’ and *her cat* (e.g., *Pasha<sub>i</sub> loves her<sub>j</sub> cat*) are derived over (52a) thorough (52b).

## (52) a. Initial structure



→→→

## b. Ultimate structure



After (52a) is built and before the VI is applied, D2 and D1 undergo fusion, thereby creating a

arbitrary. It should be the case that head-head (lateral), spec-head (upward) or head-comp (downward), but not spec-spec, comp-comp or spec-comp, is subject to fusion. Given that D3 and D2 are both specifiers, they do not undergo fusion. That is, [phi] and [ref] do not undergo clustering, where [poss] is present. When [poss] is present with other features, it can be clustered with them.

<sup>18</sup> However, *tüün-ne* is mostly absent at PF, arguably because of a language-specific morpho-phonological principle, which favors a more economical spell out. *Tüün-ne* is most likely overt when it produces a distinctive interpretation such as an intensive interpretation. If a distinctive interpretation is not obtained, the presence of *tüün-ne* lowers the acceptability of the sentence. Similar facts are observed in languages such as Chinese, in which *ta* ‘he/she’ in *ta zi-ji* or *ta zi-ji de* ‘her/his own’ may be absent if there is no semantic contribution it can make.

<sup>19</sup> Consequently, *öör-in* is the most likely ultimate realization of the embedded DP. *Bey-in* is also a likely option. However, due to the degree of lexicalization of *bey* as a body anaphor and the retention of the prototypical meaning “body” to some extent, *bey-in* is less likely to be used in possessive DPs expressing an alienable possession as in *my book*. With inalienable possession (as in *my strength*), *bey-in* is more likely to be used, as in *bey-in čadal*, which literally means “body’s strength”.

<sup>20</sup> A similar principle is Siddiqi’s (2006: 82) Minimize Exponence: the most economical derivation will be the one that maximally realizes all the formal features of the derivation with the fewest morphemes.

single node, with [phi] and [poss] clustered on it, as in (52b). Then, the VI applies and *mini/her* is inserted into  $D_{[\text{phi}, \text{poss}]}$ . While the derivation of possessive DPs is universal, Mongolian and English differ in that the spell-out form of  $D_{[\text{phi}, \text{poss}]}$  (i.e., *mini*) can be absent at PF in Mongolian, but not in English. This difference is attributed to the fact that Mongolian is a zero-determiner language whereas English is an obligatory-determiner language (Bai et al. 2026). The parametric difference concerning determiners between Mongolian and English also accounts for why the possessive personal pronoun spelling out  $D_{[\text{phi}, \text{poss}]}$  is preferably or necessarily absent at PF in Mongolian (53), but obligatorily present in English (54).

(53) Baatar           \*(tüün-ne)   öör-in       nom- $\phi$ -oo       mart-san.  
       Baatar-NOM   3SG-GEN   self-GEN   book-ACC-RX   forget-PST  
       ‘Baatar forgot his own book.’

(54) Pasha<sub>i</sub> loves \*(her<sub>i</sub>) cat.

As regards *her* in the anaphoric use (54), it is significantly justified by Bai et al. (2026) that English does have possessive anaphors, contrary to the previous claim (Gelderen 2000; Büring 2005; Reuland 2007, 2011; Truswell 2014; Despić 2015) that English lacks them. An important finding from Bai et al. (2026) is that possessive pronouns like *her* in their anaphoric use are not lexically reflexive; rather, they are accompanied by a hidden reflexive element *own* as the exponence of  $D_{[\text{ref}, \text{poss}]}$ , which is syntactically present while being optionally present at PF, as is the case with many other languages. For example, for Chinese *ta (zi-ji) de* ‘her/his own’ and Japanese *kare (zi-sin) no* ‘his own’, the anaphors *zi-ji* and *zi-sin* can be omitted at PF, while being present in the syntax. This means that (54) has the underlying structure (55), as opposed to (56), which is a non-reflexive structure (Bai et al. 2026).

(55) Pasha<sub>i</sub> loves [<sub>DP</sub> her<sub>i</sub> [<sub>DP</sub> own [<sub>NP</sub> cat]]]

(56) Pasha<sub>i</sub> loves [<sub>DP</sub> her<sub>j</sub> [<sub>NP</sub> cat]]

Having elaborated on the internal organization of anaphors,<sup>21</sup> we proceed to discuss how binding takes place during the process of their portmanteau derivation.

## 5. Explaining reflexive binding

We first derive the distinction of predicate-internal binding and predicate-external binding and discuss its implications for some of current debates on binding in Section 5.1 and implement binding in Section 5.2.

### 5.1. Predicate-internal binding vs. Predicate-external binding

Reuland (2001, 2005, 2011, 2020) among many others presents a line of reasoning in which binding is Agree, which is an operation for DP subjects to value phi-features on anaphors. Reuland assumes that phi-features of anaphors start from Spec of TP in a binding context, where Agree requires tense as well as Case to interact with it. This is a different approach than Kratzer (2009), who argues that phi-features of anaphors start out from Spec of vP. For Kratzer (2009), binding is not feature-valuation, but rather feature-transmission, which is not Agree per se. The essential difference between feature-valuation and feature-transmission is that for the former,

<sup>21</sup> Anaphors are not exclusively possessive DPs. What have been called SE-anaphors such as Dutch *zich* do not display possessive properties on the surface. It is presumably the case that reflexivity is a continuum-like property, where possessive DP anaphors such as body-part and SELF anaphors and reflexive affixes (or null reflexivizers) represent the two extremes of the continuum.



unvalued phi-features are encoded by anaphors from the beginning, while for the latter, anaphors come to have phi-features after they receive them from a local subject. Rooryck and Vanden Wyngaerd (2011) also assume that phi-features of anaphors originate from a local subject in Spec of vP. Rooryck and Vanden Wyngaerd (2011) argue that phi-features are specified for anaphors via Agree, which takes place between anaphors and local subjects merged in Spec of vP. Rooryck and Vanden Wyngaerd (2011), however, assume that anaphors are not bindees but binders, whereas local subjects are bindees, not binders.

The following points thus have been subject to debate: What mechanism is binding? How is it achieved? Where (vP or TP) is it completed? What defines a binding domain (vP or TP)? Below, I show that these controversies arise where binding is undistinguished between predicate-internal and predicate-external.

Binding must be distinguished between internal and external. In a nutshell, internal binding is completed within the predicate phrase devoid of any tense-aspectual inflection and external binding is completed with help by tense-aspectual inflection.

(57) Internal binding:  $[TP\ XP_i\ [\text{VoiceP}\ t_i\ [\text{VP}\ \dots\ YP_i]]]$

(58) External binding:  $[TP\ XP_i\ [\text{VoiceP}\ t_i\ [\text{VP}\ \dots\ YP_i]]]$

This means that binding is derivational across the phase domain and the inflectional domain, where it exhibits distinct properties as summarized below.

(59) Predicate-internal binding vs. predicate-external binding<sup>22</sup>

| Predicate-internal binding            | Predicate-external binding           |
|---------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| binder located within the predicate   | binder located outside the predicate |
| not intertwined with tense/inflection | intertwined with tense/inflection    |
| vP as binding domain                  | TP as binding domain                 |
| not local                             | local                                |
| may or may not be reflexive-marked    | reflexive-marked                     |
| lead to the AAE                       | does not lead to the AAE             |

It is crucial that a subject as the binder is dynamically positioned; that is, the binder originates within the predicate but may be relocated outside it. Given that binding as Agree involves phi-features on a subject, it is a dynamic, streamlined, and derivational process. With tense/inflection assigned to the predicate and the subject promoted to Spec of TP, binding comes to be reassessed. Reassessed binding is on par with chain-based binding advocated by Reuland (2011) in that both involve Agree plus Move. They, however, differ in that the former starts as internal binding, which is already completed within vP, but the latter is not completed until the binder occurs in the inflectional domain. The independence of internal binding on verbal inflection as well as subjective case is evidenced by the fact that a predicate-internal subject

<sup>22</sup> As regards phase-based binding (predicate-internal binding), this paper is only concerned with binding within vP/VoiceP, while suggesting the possibility that binding within a possessive DP phase takes place with the abstract predicate *HOLD* (Section 5.2). As regards the precise category of the uninflected predicate, Bai (2025) suggests that it is VoiceP, which is a split projection, where a Voice head introduces a DP via either external or internal merge (under Chomsky's (2013, 2015) Free Merge), yielding a transitive/causative or passive structure. A passive subject thus can internally-bind an anaphor when it is in Spec of VoiceP and externally-bind it when it moves up to Spec of TP, where RX is present to mark the external binding.

can successfully bind an anaphor in Mongolian. For example, the agent (*Dorž*) in (60), being the subject of the embedded VoiceP, binds the anaphor, in contrast with the case with (61), in which the causer *Baatar*, occupying Spec of the inflected predicate phrase (TP), binds the anaphor. Importantly, the two instances of binding are distinctively marked by respective morphemes. Only in predicate-external binding is RX the marker.

(60) Baatar<sub>i</sub> [VoiceP *t<sub>i</sub>* [VoiceP Dorž<sub>j</sub>-oor öör<sub>i</sub>/\*<sub>j</sub>-ig-ni šüümžil] -үүл] -sen.  
 Baatar-NOM Dorž-INS self-ACC-POSS[3] criticize-CS-PST  
 ‘Baatar made Dorž criticize himself (= Dorž).’

(61) Baatar<sub>i</sub> [VoiceP *t<sub>i</sub>* [VoiceP Dorž<sub>j</sub>-oor öör<sub>i</sub>/\*<sub>j</sub>-ig-öö šüümžil] -үүл] -sen.  
 Baatar-NOM Dorž-INS self-ACC-RX criticize-CS-PST  
 ‘Baatar made Dorž criticize him (= Baatar).’

In (60) and (61), the agent is located within the predicate, which is VoiceP (Bai 2025), and binds the anaphor.<sup>23</sup> Not being the hierarchically highest argument in the voice/predicate domain, the agent does not move up to Spec of TP, but the causer as the highest argument does. That is, for an in-situ subject, which is not the highest argument, binding remains as internal binding, and for a derived subject, which is the highest argument, binding starts as internal but becomes external binding.<sup>24</sup>

The reassessment is re-marked where the language, for example, Mongolian, provides distinct morphology than the anaphor available as the marker. Where no distinct morphology is available, the anaphor remains as the marker. Cross-linguistically, internal binding of possessors may or may not be anaphoric-marked, as in (62–65).<sup>25</sup>

(62) Pasha<sub>i</sub> loves her<sub>i</sub> cat.

(63) Pasha (öör-in) muur- $\phi$ -aa hairla-na. [Mongolian]  
 Pasha-NOM self-GEN cat-ACC-RX love-NPST  
 ‘Pasha loves her (own) cat.’ (= (43))

(64) Pasha<sub>i</sub> xihuan ta<sub>i</sub> (ziji)-de mao. [Chinese]  
 Pasha love she (self)-GEN cat  
 ‘Pasha loves her (own) cat.’ (= (44))

(65) Pasha<sub>i</sub> kanozyo<sub>i</sub> (zisin)-no neko-o ai-suru. [Japanese]  
 Pasha she (self)-GEN cat-ACC love-NPST  
 ‘Pasha loves her (own) cat.’ (= (45))

<sup>23</sup> In Mongolian, an instrumental causee is the subject of the transitive verb stem, as significantly demonstrated by Bai (2025). This is also evidenced by (60), in which the instrumental causee antecedes the anaphor. Gong and Despić (2026) claim that Mongolian instrumental causees are adjuncts rather than arguments, whereby supporting their analysis of RX. However, their diagnoses all fail, the details of which are left out here due to the space limitation. If instrumental causees were adjuncts, then dative and accusative causees would also be adjuncts in Mongolian, since they would be the same under Gong and Despić’s (2026) diagnostic tests. Gong and Despić’s (2026) tests would also render agentive causees non-argumental cross-linguistically.

<sup>24</sup> Borjigin and Bai (2025) justified that the Reflexive-Possessive Principle in Mongolian is a type of Binding Principle A of the standard binding theory, which further demonstrates that external binding indeed exists as an independent type of binding, which is composed of Agree and Move and overtly marked by RX.

<sup>25</sup> These sentences show that anaphors are not the definite marker of reflexivity and syntactic binding cross-linguistically; where binding does not obtain, they may be simply the marker of coreference within or beyond a sentence, leading to phenomena such as logophoricity. A theory should not take the presence or absence of an anaphoric element to in determining reflexivity and syntactic binding.

Languages such as English, Chinese, and Japanese do not necessarily distinctively mark external and internal bindings due to the lack of relevant morphology in the morphological inventory in them; that is, reassessment of binding within TP is left unmarked in these languages. In contrast, Mongolian marks both internal and external binding.

One might say that external binding should be anaphoric-marked in order to be distinguished from unmarked internal binding in cases like (62). However, this is not the case because internal binding is completed within vP, which is a phase, and due to PIC, the morphology of the bindee, the possessor, is not subject to change when the structure extends to TP. Therefore, in (63), external binding is not subject to anaphoric-marking although the internal binding is not anaphoric-marked.

TP as a binding domain in the standard binding theory is incompatible with Minimalism. This is because binding in the standard binding theory is an independent module of grammar and binding conditions are representational constraints, while binding under minimalist assumptions is a derivational process, where binding domain is assumed to be determined by phasehood. However, TP should still be a binding domain, without rejecting a phase such as vP as another binding domain. This paper demonstrates that the identification of TP as a binding domain follows from the deriving external-binding from internal-binding, and that *locality of reflexive binding is determined by the inflectional properties of the predicate* and perhaps structural Case as well. That is, external, not internal, binding qualifies as local reflexive binding, as evidenced in inflected local clauses like those in (23), (25), and (61), repeated as (66), (67), and (68).

(66) Baatar<sub>i</sub>            Dorž<sub>j</sub>-in        öör<sub>i/j</sub>-ig-öö        šüümžil-sen-ig        har-san.  
 Baatar-NOM   Dorž-GEN   self-ACC-RX   criticize-PST-ACC   see-PST  
 ‘Baatar saw that Dorž criticized himself (= Dorž).’

(67) Baatar<sub>i</sub>            Dorž<sub>j</sub>-ig        öör<sub>i/j</sub>-ig-öö        šüümžil-sen        gež        bod-son.  
 Baatar-NOM   Dorž-ACC   self-ACC-RX   criticize-PST   COMP   think-PST  
 ‘Baatar thought that Dorž criticized himself (= Dorž).’

(68) Baatar<sub>i</sub>            Dorž<sub>j</sub>-oor        öör<sub>i/j</sub>-ig-öö        šüümžil-үүл-sen.  
 Baatar-NOM   Dorž-INS   self-ACC-RX   criticize-CS-PST  
 ‘Baatar made Dorž criticize him (= Baatar).’

The Anaphor Agreement Effect (AAE) (Rizzi 1990) states that anaphors cannot directly participate in phi-agreement that pronouns can do with appropriate antecedent nominals. Although it is not universal (Sundaresan 2016; Rudnev 2023), AAE is attested cross-linguistically. This arguably has to do with internal binding. Specifically, it is the status of the subject being a predicate-internal subject in Spec of VoiceP/vP, rather than the structure of anaphor as the bindee, that induces AAE, contrary to Preminger (2019). Located within a predicate lacking tense/inflectional properties, a predicate-internal subject can be described as “immature” as a binder due to the lack of structural Case, aligning with Reuland’s (2011) observation that binding is intertwined with the structural Case of the binder. Thus, the immaturity of predicate-internal subjects leads to AAE.

Reflexivity conditioned by internal binding is thus modest reflexivity, while reflexivity conditioned by external binding is full reflexivity. It is supposed to be the case that full reflexivity needs marking in a greater degree than modest reflexivity. This leads to the fact that RX is required for binding in inflected, rather than uninflected, contexts.

## 5.2. Implementing binding

The analysis of binding to propose in this subsection results from the combination of the “portmanteau-formation” analysis of anaphors (Section 4.2) and the Agree analysis of binding. This paper, however, does not use chain-formation that Reuland (2011) does.

To elaborate, [phi] sits on D from the beginning and gets valued when the structure is built up to involve merger of the subject in Spec of VoiceP (roughly corresponding to vP).

(69) [TP ... [VoiceP sbj<sub>[phi]</sub> [DP ... D<sub>[phi]</sub> ... [NP ... ] ... ] ... ] ... ]

The case in which [poss] is involved is illustrated by Mongolian reflexive possessive pronoun (*mini*) *öör-in*. Fusion applies to [poss] and [phi] as well as to [poss] and [ref], followed by VI, which chooses *mini* and *öör-in* for the relevant D heads, respectively.

(70) [TP [VoiceP sbj<sub>[phi]</sub> [DP ... D<sub>[phi, poss]</sub> ... D<sub>[ref, poss]</sub> ... [NP ... ] ... ] ... ] ... ]

D<sub>[ref, poss]</sub>, however, is irrelevant to the implementation of binding; what is relevant is ([phi] in [phi, poss]. After valued, [phi, poss] is assigned the morpheme *mini*, for example. With binding established, [ref] in [ref, poss] gets evoked and a reflexive interpretation is produced.

The proposed analysis successfully accounts for the binding of accusative and genitive anaphors as well as binding into nominals and inflected clauses, with or without *gež*, in a unified way. As summarized in (12) and (13), a matrix subject can bind the accusative subject of object clauses with *gež* (71) and the genitive subject of object clauses without *gež* (72). Note that such object clauses are all inflected. With *gež*, they are CP, and without it, they are TP.

(71) Baatar            öör-ig-öö            buruud-san            gež            med-sen.  
Baatar-NOM   self-ACC-RX   go wrong-PST   COMP   know-PST  
‘Baatar realized that he was wrong.’            (=7))

(72) Baatar            (öör-in)            buruud-san-aa            meder-sen.  
Baatar-NOM   self-GEN   go wrong-PST-RX   admit-PST  
‘Baatar admitted that he was wrong.’            (=9))

We need to first determine the position of the genitive and accusative subjects. Fong (2019) observed that the accusative subject of *gež* clauses is raised to Spec of CP, thereby becoming accessible from the matrix v. Thus, *öör* of *öör-ig-öö* in (71) is within the minimal matrix phase as the binding domain and is bound by the matrix subject in Spec of vP (73).

(73) [TP [vP Baatar<sub>i</sub> [CP öör<sub>i</sub>-ig-öö C [TP t<sub>i</sub> [vP t<sub>i</sub> buruud ] -san ] gež ] med ] -sen ]

This is exactly what is predicted in Bošković’s (2016) formulation.

(74) [A]<sub>n</sub> anaphor can be bound outside of its own minimal phase XP only if it is located at the edge of the phase (the anaphor then does not really ‘belong’ to phase XP; rather, it belongs to a higher phase). (Bošković 2016: 14)

The genitive anaphor *öör-in* as the subject of object clauses such as (72) is located in Spec of DP that contains a clausal structure. Specifically, TP is selected by D<sub>[poss]</sub> with the *HOLD* semantics. This is plausible given that TPs are subject to nominalization (Kornfilt and Whitman 2011, 2012). In this sense, the genitive subject is some kind of possessor that holds the event as a possessum under its control. Gong and Despić (2024, 2026) reason out that TP nominalization takes place in Mongolian. All this said, this paper argues that the genitive case marker *-in* in *öör-in* is the spell-out form of the possessive D head, whose Spec is occupied by *öör*, as illustrated below.

(75) [TP [vP Baatar<sub>i</sub> [DP öör<sub>i</sub> D(=in) [TP [vP t<sub>i</sub> buruud ] -san-aa ] ] meder ] -sen ]

To elaborate, a bare D with an unvalued [phi] and [ref] is introduced as an external argument by  $\nu$ , and subsequently moves to Spec of DP. Since *öör-in*, located in Spec of DP, is outside of the minimal phase DP (D' traditionally), it is accessible from the matrix clause. This makes it possible that [phi] on *öör* is valued by that on the matrix subject via Agree/binding, thereby evoking [ref]. After fusion applies, VI chooses the morpheme *öör-in* for  $D_{[ref, poss]}$ .  $D_{[phi, poss]}$  is realized as the third person singular possessive pronoun *tüün-ne*, which, however, is mostly absent due to principles of economy such as (48). Interestingly, such principles even allow the spell-out form of  $D_{[ref, poss]}$  (i.e., *öör-in*) to be absent at PF, where RX is available elsewhere (76).<sup>26</sup>

(76) Baatar            buruud-san-aa            meder-sen.  
       Baatar-NOM   go wrong-PST-RX   admit-PST  
       ‘Baatar admitted that he was wrong.’

The same holds true in the case of relative clauses, in which the relative subject is the genitive anaphor *öör-in*, exemplified below.

(77) Baatar            (öör-in)            hel-sen            üg-φ-ee            mart-san.  
       Baatar-NOM   self-GEN-RX   say-PST   word-ACC-RX   forget-PST  
       ‘Baatar forgot the words he said.’                    (= (11))

In (77), the relative clause is located in Spec of NP, and a bare D with unvalued [phi] and [ref], which is base-generated in Spec of  $\nu P$ , moves out from the clause (TP/RC) to Spec of DP, headed by  $D_{[poss]}$ . Fusion applies so that  $D_{[ref, poss]}$  and  $D_{[phi, poss]}$  are derived. Since [phi] is now within the same domain as the matrix subject, it gets the value of [phi] on the matrix subject and [ref] is evoked. VI applies and *öör-in* spells out  $D_{[ref, poss]}$  (78), as is the case with (75).

(78)  $[TP \text{ } [_{\nu P} \text{ Baatar}_i \text{ } [_{DP} \text{ öör}_i \text{ } D \text{ } [_{NP} \text{ } [TP(=RC) \text{ } [_{\nu P} \text{ } t_i \text{ hel } ] \text{ -sen } ] \text{ üg-ee } ] ] \text{ mart } ] \text{ -san } ]$

It is important to note here that locality in cross-clausal binding is achieved by raising the embedded subject to the edge of the maximal CP phase for *gež* clauses and by nominalizing clauses without *gež* into possessive DPs and locating the anaphoric element in their edges. Such cross-clausal binding and within-clausal binding share a common structure mimicking a possessive DP, where reflexive binding is a linkage between specifiers, not simply between a specifier and a complement, in a local domain.

## 6. Categorical status and position of RX

Traditional grammarians have treated RX as a reflexive possessive suffix, without discussing its exact status. Among theoretical studies, Maki et al. (2015: 67ff) label RX “pronoun” and Gong and Despić (2024, 2026) treat it as a D head. Maki et al. (2015: 67ff) proposed that RX undergoes LF movement to its antecedent, e.g., the subject. However, RX can never be an element that can be characterized as a reflexive pronoun. It lacks a specification of any nominal features, which a pronoun may have. Functionally, RX is similar to anaphors (or reflexive pronouns), but it must belong to a different category.

### 6.1. Gong and Despić (2024, 2026): -AA as D

Gong and Despić (2024, 2026) discuss RX in terms of Condition A and proposes the following.

<sup>26</sup> The presence of *öör-in* brings an intensifying effect on the possessor. That is, normally *öör-in* is not present at PF unless there is an intensification requirement. See Footnote 7 for relevant discussion.

(79) RX (her REFL.POSS -AA) signals agreement with a minimal pronoun bound by the closest  $v$  which introduces the local subject.

- i. Binding mechanism: Binding by  $v$ .
- ii. Nature of bound (reflexive) pronoun: Minimal Pronouns (MIN)
- iii. Morpho-syntactic source of -RX: Feature Transmission

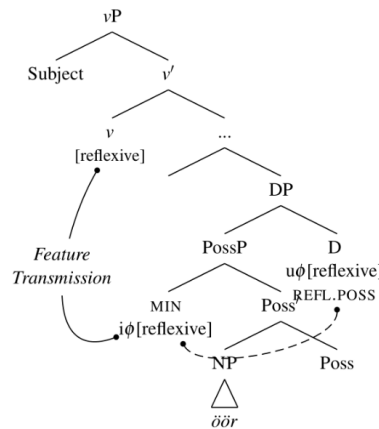
This proposal is based on Kratzer (2009), who argues that it is the local functional head  $v$  rather than an antecedent DP that serves as the binder of reflexives, which acquire their phi-feature set from  $v$  via Feature Transmission under Binding (FTUB).

(80) Feature Transmission under Binding (Kratzer 2009: 216)

The  $\phi$ -feature set of a locally bound pronoun unifies with the  $\phi$ -feature set of the head that hosts its binder.

On this account, reflexives are elements born without  $\phi$ -features, which Kratzer (2009) called MIN, for minimal pronoun. Following Kratzer (2009), Gong and Despić (2024, 2026) assume that there is MIN in Mongolian, which is base-generated in Spec of nP, sharing  $\phi$ -features with D, and moves to Spec of DP due to EPP on D. Having moved to Spec of DP, MIN remains in the same domain as  $v$ . FTUB applies and MIN receives the feature [ref] from  $v$ . Since MIN shares this feature with D, as a result it is present on three heads including  $v$ , MIN, and D, and is spelled out as RX on D.

(81) Derivation of *öör-ig-öö* (82):



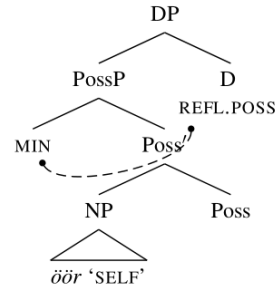
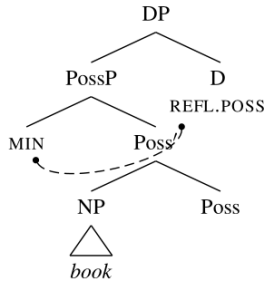
Gong and Despić (2026: 15)

(82) Dorž            *öör-ig-öö*            *šüümžil-sen*.  
Dorž-NOM    self-ACC-RX    criticize-PST  
‘Dorž criticized himself.’    (= (2))

As regards *öör*, Gong and Despić (2024, 2026) treat it as a NP complement of a possessive head Poss (81), whose projection PossP in turn is the complement of the D head realized as RX(-AA), yielding a consistently right-head nominal structure [[[NP *öör*] PossP] -öö DP]. The structure of *nom-φ-oo* (84) is derived as in (83a), compared with that of *öör-ig-öö* (83b).

(83) a. Derivation of *nom-φ-oo* (84):                      b. Derivation of *öör-ig-öö* (82)





Gong and Despić (2026: 12)

- (84) Baatar          nom- $\phi$ -oo          mart-san.  
 Baatar-NOM   book-ACC-**RX**   forget-PST  
 ‘Baatar forgot his own book.’

Given (83), the anaphor *öör* and a common noun, *nom* ‘book’ here, are the same in that both are NPs selected by Poss. By treating them alike, Gong and Despić (2026) derive objects as in (82) and (84) in the same manner, where they assume a null possessor MIN in Spec of PossP.

While Gong and Despić’s idea that the reflexive property takes shape via the link between the nominal domain and *v* is valuable, their attempt to derive the object DPs as in (82) and (84) in the same manner by assuming a null possessor MIN causes important empirical problems. **First**, it is incorrect to interpret the anaphor *öör* as a possessum. *Öör* is a possessor as evidently indicated by the body anaphor *öör-in bey* ‘self’s body’. Additionally, *öör* in genitive case can be recovered as the possessor (85).

- (85) Baatar          öör-in          nom- $\phi$ -oo          mart-san.  
 Baatar-NOM   self-GEN   book-ACC-**RX**   forget-PST  
 ‘Baatar forgot his own book.’      (= (5))

**Second**, the incorrect parallelism between (83a) and (83b), where the anaphor *öör* is treated as the same as an NP complement such as *nom* ‘book’, makes it unclear where to locate *öör* in *öör-in nom-oo* ‘one’s own book’ (86), given that *nom* ‘book’ is already located under NP.

- (86) Baatar          öör-in-h-**öö**<sup>27</sup>          nom-ig          mart-san.  
 Baatar-NOM   self-GEN-h-**RX**   book-ACC   forget-PST  
 ‘Baatar forgot his own book.’

Gong and Despić (2026: 6–9) incorrectly interpret *öör-in-h-öö* (their *öör-iin-kh-öö*) as an argumental element, while correctly taking *öör-in* as a non-argumental modifier, because they confused the modifier *öör-in-h*, which is an independent element, with the argumental *öör-in-h*, which is a dependent element, where *-h* functions differently. Specifically, in the former, *-h* (“H1” in (87); e.g., (86)) is inserted between the consonant *n* and *öö* simply for phonological reasons (Footnote 6; Cinggeltei 1999: 181; Janhunen 2012: 141; etc.), whereas in the latter, *-h* (“H2” in (87); e.g., (88)) is the realization of a syntactic node (Bai et al. 2025), although it may be absent at PF when followed by dative case marking *-d*, as in *tedne- $\phi$ -d* ‘to their home’ (Kullmann and Tserenpil 2015: 102; Bai et al. 2025). Note that the purely phonological *-h*, not the morpho-syntactic *-h*, is null in Uyghur orthography, while it is written as “x” in Cyrillic orthography, indicating that it is not the same as the other.

#### (87) Two types of *-h*

<sup>27</sup> The consonant *h* in such cases excluding the present example is left out (*öör-in-öö*) in this paper (Cf. Footnote 6).

|                         | H1                                     | H2                        |
|-------------------------|----------------------------------------|---------------------------|
| Cyrillic orthography    | -x (e.g., өөрийнхөө/öör-in-h-öö)       | -x (e.g., ахынх/ah-in-h)  |
| Uyghur orthography      | null (e.g., ئۆبەر-ۇن-يەن/öber-un-iyen) | ئا (e.g., اھئا/aha-in-hi) |
| Morpho-syntactic status | Empty                                  | Pronominal complement     |

(88) Bi ah-in-h-ig unš-b.

I older brother-GEN-h-ACC read-PST

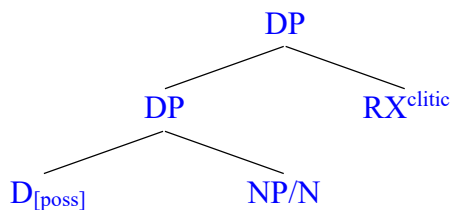
‘I read my older brother’s.’ (Kullmann and Tserenpil 2015: 102)

**Third**, assuming that a D head follows NP is incompatible with the fact that DPs are always head-initial in Mongolian like many other languages. Gong and Despić (2026: 17) argue that Mongolian encodes definiteness postnominally by assuming that POSS[3] *-ni* functions purely as a definite marker. Indeed, POSS[3] can go with a definite interpretation. However, it can never be categorially a determiner since it cooccurs with a dedicated determiner as in *ter nom ni* ‘that book (of someone)’,<sup>28</sup> personal possessive pronoun as in *tedne ger ni* ‘their home’, and even proper noun as in *Baatar ni* ‘Baatar (who belongs to or associated with some group or community)’, although Mongolian lacks a definite article. **Fourth**, Gong and Despić’s (2026: 13–14) assumption that Mongolian is a language that tolerates Mirror Principle violations (Baker 1985) in nominal domain does not make sense. The fact that RX is the rightmost element, following any other nominal inflections including those for number and case, suggests that it is hierarchically higher than case suffixes, strictly aligning with the Mirror Principle. **Fifth**, the overall structure they design for the Mongolian anaphor fails to capture of the PIPE (phase-in-phase-edge) phenomenon in Mongolian: The possessor can be recursively embedded within a DP phase, which is located in the edge of another phase (Bai 2026). Given these difficulties, it is not appropriate to treat RX as a D head and *öör* as a noun.

## 6.2. *-AA* as a clitic

Given that RX is an outermost (rightmost) element in a DP, it should occupy an adjunct/specifier position. However, this would imply that it is a phrasal element, contrary to the fact that it does not display any properties displayed by phrases; it lacks a specification of phi-features (person, gender and number) and is unable to move. This in turn indicates that it is a head-like element.<sup>29</sup> This ambivalent property of RX suggests that it is in fact a clitic-like element. Note that clitics are generated as specifiers of a null head (Bošković 1997b, 2002b). This leads us to the following representation (89), in which RX sits in the rightmost specifier of DP.

(89) Position of RX as a clitic<sup>30</sup>



<sup>28</sup> Postnominal possessive marker can cooccur with a definite article, as evidenced by Basque *ton eafió tu* ‘Lit. his self’ (Haspelmath 2023: 26), where the anaphor *eafió* is sandwiched between the two elements.

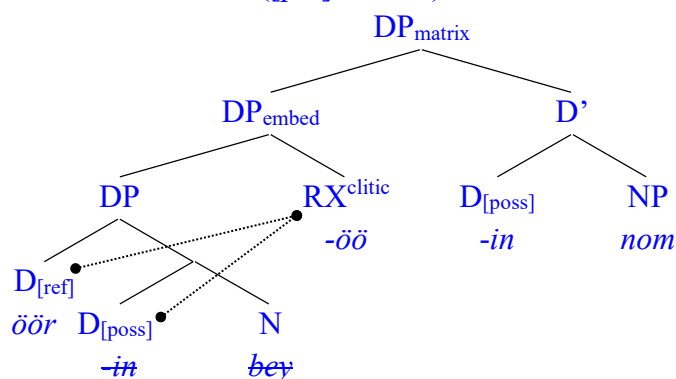
<sup>29</sup> See Chomsky (1995a), Bošković (1997b, 2002b), and Reinhart (2016) for relevant discussion on the ambiguous property of clitics, which behave like both  $X^0$  or XP.

<sup>30</sup> Notably, RX is a nominal clitic, unlike, for example, what is referred to as the “reflexive clitic” *se* in Romance and Slavic languages, which is identified as a verbal clitic (Reinhart 2016: 189–191).

Given this, RX occurs to the right of NP/N (85). Note, however, that RX can also occur to the left of N (86). As shown below, the actual linear string *öör-in-öö nom* ‘self’s/own book’ (90a) may have the structure in (90b), where the spell-out forms of the embedded D<sub>[poss]</sub> (*-in*) and N (*bey*) will be absent at PF (Cf. Section 4.2), represented by the strikethrough. RX is to the left of the matrix D<sub>[poss]</sub> (*-in*) in the hierarchical structure (90b). The resulting linear structure would thus like (91), contrary to the actual linear order (90a). Note that *-in* in the surface structure is the realization of the matrix D<sub>[poss]</sub>, not the embedded D<sub>[poss]</sub>. The embedded D<sub>[poss]</sub> is absent at PF.

(90)a. Actual linear ordering: *öör-GEN-RX* NP (e.g., *öör-in-öö nom* ‘self’s book’)<sup>31</sup>

b. Hierarchical structure ([phi] left out):



(91) Reverse linear ordering: *öör-RX-GEN* NP (e.g., *öör-öö-in nom* ‘self’s book’)

Resulting in the non-existent linear string (91), the hierarchical structure in (90b) might appear incorrect. However, there is solid reasoning for justifying its correctness. The crux of the matter is to determine how RX is constrained by a morpho-phonological principle in addition to syntactic rules. It is evident that RX is not part of an anaphor or a pronoun. It is simply a marker of reflexivity with a status of clitic. Since it is a clitic, RX is not able to project in syntax. Phonologically, RX is subject to vowel harmony, as also suggested by the fact that it has allophonic variants such as *-aa*, *-oo*, *-öö*, and *-ee*. This indicates that what determines the position of RX is not only a syntactic rule such as binding but also a spell-out rule. This said, it is reasonable that the insertion of RX into the structure takes place after the insertion of all other materials required in forming an anaphor and spelling out a possessive relation. This is to say that D<sub>[ref]</sub> in the embedded DP (DP<sub>embed</sub>) and the matrix D<sub>[poss]</sub> are spelled out first by *öör-in*, which is inserted as an **inseparable morphological unit**, and then RX is inserted into a **linear, not hierarchical, position adjacent to öör-in**, resulting in *öör-in-öö*. Let us refer to this as “the Late Insertion Rule”, which is informally stated as follows.

(92) The Late Insertion Rule (LIR)

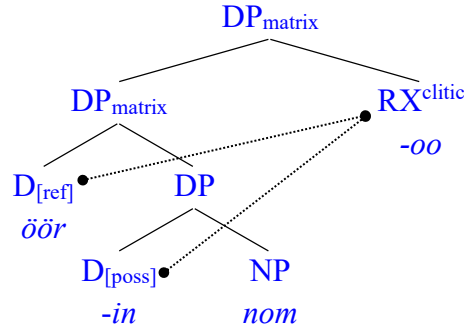
**RX is inserted after the morpheme(s) required for DP formation are inserted.**

LIR, essentially a spell-out rule, interacts with a syntactic condition to describe below. RX being subject to LIR implies that the right Spec of DP<sub>embed</sub> is empty in syntax. Notably, RX can also be inserted into a position to the right of *nom*, specifically the right Spec of DP<sub>matrix</sub>, forming *öör-in nom-oo*. In that case, *öör-in* can be absent at PF as it is not the host of RX.

<sup>31</sup> This nested DP structure is also suggested by English *your all’s* (Deal 2006), where D<sub>[phi, poss]</sub> (after fusion) and N in the embedded DP are spelled out by *you-r* and *all* respectively, and the matrix D<sub>[poss]</sub> is spelled out by *s*.

(93)a. Actual linear ordering: *öör-GEN NP-RX* (e.g., *öör-in nom-öö* ‘self’s book’)

b. Hierarchical structure ([phi] left out):



As regards (90), the position of RX is within the embedded DP in the syntax because RX is required to be *hierarchically adjacent to the possessive DP requiring it*. That is, it is required to be projected in the right Spec of DP<sub>embed</sub>, which requires it, in the syntax. RX is required by DP<sub>embed</sub> because there is D<sub>[poss]</sub>, which heads the embedded possessive structure (DP<sub>embed</sub>). The common property of (90) and (93) is that the syntactic position of RX c-commands the possessive D head (D<sub>[poss]</sub>), which determines where RX is projected in the syntax. Put another way, D<sub>[poss]</sub> wants RX to be adjacent to its own projection.<sup>32</sup> Let us refer to this property as “the adjacent condition”, which is informally stated as follows.

(94) The Adjacent Condition (AC)<sup>33</sup>

RX is hierarchically a sister of DP, D being a possessive determiner head and its Spec bound by the subject of a local inflected clause.

The syntactic position of RX is thus determined by AC and its linear position is determined by LIR, which is preceded by AC but has an adjusting effect on it during the process of derivation. AC accounts for and is supported by the fact that embedded *gež* clauses allow neither a genitive subject nor a rightmost RX (71), whereas embedded clauses without *gež* allow both a genitive subject and a rightmost RX (72). *Gež* clauses are CPs and therefore are not subject to nominalization, unlike object clauses without *gež* and relative clauses, which are TPs (Cf. Section 5.2). Failing to have a nominal status, they cannot be selected by D<sub>[poss]</sub>, and therefore do not satisfy AC. Due to the lack of D<sub>[poss]</sub>, genitive subjects are disallowed in *gež* clauses. Recall that the accusative subject *öör-ig* in *gež* clauses must not be absent from PF (72). This is because a rightmost RX is disallowed where D<sub>[poss]</sub> is lacking, due to AC (specifically due to the lack of D<sub>[poss]</sub>). With the absence of the rightmost RX, the accusative subject does not satisfy EMC in (14), repeated as (95). In contrast, nominalized clauses (structurally, TP dominated by a possessive DP) allow a rightmost RX because they are headed by a possessive D head, which ensures that AC is satisfied by allowing the rightmost RX. Nominalized clauses have a genitive subject and allow it to be absent, where EMC is satisfied.

(95) The Elsewhere Marker Condition (EMC)

Genitive anaphors can be absent at PF when the associated RX is present elsewhere.

<sup>32</sup> An alternative way to interpret this is that RX (the marker of reflexivity) needs to be as close as possible to the locus of reflexivity (i.e., D<sub>[ref]</sub>) in the syntax, whether it is fused with D<sub>[poss]</sub> or not.

<sup>33</sup> AC as well as LIR is not presented as a universally holding principle. For the moment, it remains a stipulative formulation of a language-specific property. Where any cross-linguistic facts are found to be supportive of it, AC as well as LIR would prove to be a more general property.

## 7. Conclusion

Mongolian reflexive binding strategies, centered on the dedicated reflexive possessive suffix RX (-AA), can serve as morphological evidence for or against different current theories of binding. The hallmark of binding in Mongolian is not an anaphor (*öör*) but rather a suffix (-AA); a bound possessive anaphor can be absent at PF but the suffix in question cannot in a local binding domain, where locality is determined by verbal inflection. Local binding is obligatorily RX-marked and optionally anaphoric-marked, whereas long-distance (non-local) binding, which is not reflexive, is just anaphoric-marked.

At least six important implications arise from the Mongolian reflexive binding strategies and the proposed analysis of them, suggesting more general cognitive properties concerning binding, reflexivity, and anaphors. **First**, binding is derivational, not representational; binding domain is contextual, not fixed; the position of binders is variable, not uniform; crucially, the position of subject as binders entails the morpho-syntactic properties of binding; the inflectional properties of the predicate entailing Move of subjects derives predicate-external binding from predicate-internal binding. **Second**, binding is feature-valuation, not feature-transmission, where the values of the phi-features of a nominal occupying Spec of vP are copied to a c-commanded anaphor. **Third**, the size of clauses required for locality is universally the same but the ways of achieving locality vary among languages, where the morpho-syntactic properties related to the tense-inflection system (or TP-FinP-CP) and clause-nominalization in individual languages play important roles. **Fourth**, reflexivity can be a dependency between specifiers, where the binder occupies a subject, internal or derived, position, and the bindee occupies the (highest) specifier in the complement with respect to the same predicate. **Fifth**, there is a deeper structural link not only between anaphors and possessives but also between possessive nominals and nominalized clauses with a genitive subject. **Sixth**, the Anaphor Agreement Effect arises with predicate-internal binding, where the subject is within the uninflected predicate, being “immature” as a subject and a binder; it does not arise from a capsule-like structure of anaphors.

The primary contribution of the proposed analysis in this paper lies in the characterization of binding as a derivational process across the phase boundary and inflectional domain, which leads to the division of predicate-internal binding and predicate-external binding, and in technical elaborations of how binding steps into the internal structure of anaphors.

The intertwining between binding and the possessive structure of anaphors is the key to resolving the issues debated around the question of what mechanism binding is exactly, which is the **first** controversy mentioned in the introduction. Specifically, binding initially arises as the Agreement/valuation between phi-features on the element occupying the edge/Spec position of a VoiceP/vP phase, and those on Spec of the anaphor as a possessive DP, and then is reassessed upon the promotion of the subject into the inflectional domain. This novel argument aligns with the previously justified binding-as-phi-agreement (binding-as-feature-valuation) approach (Reuland and Everaert 2000; Reuland 2001, 2005, 2011, 2020; Reuland and Zubkov 2022).

As regards the **second** controversy, the correlation between the dynamic status of binding and the (un)inflected status of the predicate as well as subject positions (Spec of VoiceP/vP and Spec of TP) shows that *binding domain is not a fixed projection and that it may change in the same derivation*. Crucially, local inflectional projections (such as TP) serve as the strict domain for external binding, which is *the result of “Agree + Move”, not simply “Agree”*. As regards

internal binding, the phasal projection (such as Voice/vP) serves as its domain, which is not necessarily within the local TP; it can be within the matrix (non-local) TP, where long-distance binding of an anaphor within the embedded TP takes place.

The **third** controversy (mentioned in the introduction) was resolved by analyzing anaphors, not all anaphors though, as possessive DPs consisting of a possessive feature, phi-features, a reflexivity feature, and a nominal, where the determiner with the possessive feature is the head. Anaphors are thus DPs with a possessive, not capsule-like, structure. Due to principles of morphological economy, it is often the case that the nodes of the possessive DP are partially or minimally realized as single morphological units at PF within or across languages. It is also presumably the case that the possessive structure can be condensed into a simpler structure, which tends to be realized as a simple, idiosyncratic anaphoric form. This is due to the morphological/lexical inventory of individual languages and/or language-specific spell-out rules, which play important roles in interpreting and structuring anaphors and reflexivity. Reflexivity arises as a coreferential dependency not only between specifiers and complements but also between specifiers, subject to locality constraints in the syntax. On the other hand, the possessive DP analysis of anaphors predicts the continuum nature of reflexivity and/or anaphoric elements, where the full-fledged possessive structure such as Mongolian *öör-in-bey* and may represent an extreme of the continuum, while the simplest anaphor, which is often part of the reflexive predicate, such as Chinese *zi* (in *zize* ‘self-blame’) or a “null” anaphor as in *John washed*, may represent the other extreme. If this proves to be the case, *own*-anaphors (Bai et al. 2026), SELF-anaphors, and SE-anaphors (such as Dutch *zich*) may be arranged somewhere between the two extremes of the continuum. Separate papers take up these issues.

## Abbreviations

|                  |                    |                            |
|------------------|--------------------|----------------------------|
| ACC = accusative | GEN = genitive     | PS = passive               |
| ASP = aspect     | INS = instrumental | POSS = possessive particle |
| CS = causative   | NFIN = non-finite  | PST = past                 |
| DAT = dative     | NOM = nominative   | RX = reflexive-possessive  |

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